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UPSA
UNIVERSITY OF PROFESSIONAL STUDIES, ACCRA
Scholarship with Professionalism



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Report on **UPSA International Cultural Day**



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Foreword

The celebration of cultural diversity stands as a cornerstone of fostering unity, understanding, and mutual respect in our increasingly interconnected world. It is with great pride and optimism that I present this report on the International Cultural Day hosted by the University of Professional Studies, Accra (UPSA) in collaboration with the Pan-Africanism and African Culture Working Group and other esteemed partners from the European Union, GIZ, Ghanaian-European Centre, German Cooperation, and Fan Milk Ghana Limited.

Under the theme “Bridging Cultures, Shaping Futures,” the event brought together students, faculty, and distinguished guests to reflect on the transformative power of cultural exchange. Through insightful speeches, captivating performances, and engaging discussions, the day showcased the profound impact of cultural inclusivity on both individual growth and institutional progress. The enthusiastic participation of international students, renowned artists, and key stakeholders underscored the shared aspiration for a more harmonious and inclusive society.

This report captures the essence of that day, highlighting not just the moments of joy and connection, but also the critical reflections on the role of culture in shaping global citizenship. It serves as a testament to the dedication of the UPSA community and AASU in championing cultural understanding and creating spaces where diversity is not just acknowledged but celebrated.



Peter Kwasi Kodjie
Secretary-General
All-Africa Students Union (AASU)





Introduction

The University of Professional Studies, Accra (UPSA), in collaboration with the Pan-Africanism and African Culture Working Group and other esteemed partners from the European Union, GIZ, Ghanaian-European Centre, German Cooperation, and Fan Milk Ghana Limited hosted its annual Cultural Day, celebrating the rich diversity and shared heritage of its vibrant community. The conference took place on November 14th, 2024. The event brought together students, staff, and distinguished guests who emphasized the theme “Bridging Cultures, Shaping Futures”. Through captivating performances and insightful speeches, the day highlighted how embracing our differences strengthens social bonds and fosters mutual respect. This report captures the key moments and reflections from the celebration, showcasing the collective commitment to promoting a more inclusive and culturally diverse environment at UPSA.



Opening Session and Keynote Address

The program commenced with an acknowledgement of distinguished guests, including faculty, students, and the special invitees who had gathered to share in the festivities. The CEO of the CEOs was also recognized for their contribution to the event's organization. The opening remarks set the tone for the day, highlighting the significance of cultural diversity as a cornerstone of the UPSA community.

The Chairperson emphasized that while each member of the UPSA community brings a unique background, these differences serve as a bridge rather than a barrier. In his words, “Our diversity shapes the spirit of our university,



reminding us that even though we come from different backgrounds and speak different languages, our unique identities are the very threads that weave our vibrant tapestry.” This statement was echoed throughout the day’s activities, underscoring the theme of unity in diversity. The opening address by Dr. Ivy Heward Mills, director of the Australian Institute of Business, set the tone for the day, emphasizing the significance of celebrating cultural diversity and recognizing the unique contributions of every individual within the UPSA community. She extended gratitude to the CEOs and special guests, acknowledging their presence as a symbol of unity and shared experiences that enrich the cultural fabric of the university. Diversity was highlighted as a strength, shaping the spirit of UPSA and fostering empathy, tolerance, and respect among its members. She encouraged participants to embrace their heritage and actively engage in cultural exchanges, which are vital for building understanding and collaboration across different backgrounds. Continuing the theme of inclusiveness, Dr. Ivy shared personal anecdotes about bridging cultural gaps, particularly experiences with Muslim friends and shared activities such as playing football. These interactions, according to her, exemplify the positive impact of engaging with different cultures and building relationships based on mutual respect. She emphasized the importance of maintaining an ongoing commitment to celebrating culture, urging participants to respect differences and work towards a more inclusive environment. A call to action was made for everyone to uphold the spirit of Cultural Day, transforming the university into a space where all cultural expressions are valued and welcomed. She concluded by encouraging active participation in the event, reinforcing the message of fostering cultural understanding.



The Incoming Vice-Chancellor of UPSA, Dr. John Kwaku Mensah Mawutor was introduced to also give his speech. He highlighted that the diversity present at UPSA is a microcosm of the broader societal landscape, enriched by a blend of local and international influences. The Incoming Vice-Chancellor's address emphasized that “Celebrating culture is not confined to a single day; it is an ongoing commitment to respect each other’s differences, promote inclusiveness, and embrace a broader worldview.” Dr. Guinwa introduced the Lebanese Ambassador, for cultural diversity and connection.

In his remarks, the ambassador spoke about the richness that comes from sharing different cultures, traditions, and ways of life. Drawing parallels between Lebanon and Ghana, Mr. Maher highlighted the shared values of community, hospitality, and respect for heritage that unite both countries. The ambassador underscored the importance of cultural exchange in building bridges of understanding and fostering collaboration.



He commended the organizers for their vision and dedication to celebrating diversity, stressing that such events play a crucial role in shaping a future grounded in cultural awareness and inclusiveness. Mr. Maher delved into the broader social impact of culture, discussing its vital role in uniting people and shaping future generations. Mr. Maher highlighted the significance of cultural exchange in nurturing empathy, understanding, and cooperation, which are essential for addressing complex global challenges. Cultural diversity was presented as a powerful asset that can drive social progress, enhance mutual respect, and promote unity. He called on participants to serve as ambassadors of culture, advocating for tolerance and creating inclusive spaces where every voice is heard. The message was clear: embracing cultural diversity is key to building a more harmonious and equitable society.

Mr. Benjamin Domedo Nyarko was introduced next. He shared a compelling personal narrative, recounting experiences of overcoming challenges and seizing opportunities in various countries, including the UK. He reflected on the significance of hard work, perseverance, and the support of mentors in shaping their career path. These stories highlighted the resilience required to navigate different cultural environments and the invaluable lessons learned through these experiences. Mr. Nyarko emphasized the importance of embracing new opportunities and acknowledged the role of mentors and colleagues in their success. He underscored the value of teamwork and collaboration, which are crucial for achieving personal and professional growth.

Dr. Nyarko discussed the profound impact of cultural diversity on modern society and its implications for higher education. The speaker noted that technology, media, and increased societal interaction are rapidly transforming cultural norms, creating a dynamic environment that requires adaptability and openness. Cultural pluralism was highlighted as a fundamental element of cultural diversity, reflecting the multicultural nature of today's global society. He stressed the responsibility of higher education institutions like UPSA to foster cultural understanding and prepare students for global citizenship. By embracing cultural differences, universities can create environments that promote learning, innovation, and social cohesion. In the final remarks, there was an appeal to everyone present to continue championing cultural inclusiveness beyond the event, shaping a future defined by cooperation, respect, and shared humanity. The message was clear: the true celebration of culture goes beyond a single day—it is an ongoing commitment to understanding, learning, and valuing the diverse traditions that make up our shared world.

Celebrating Diversity through Performances

The day's activities were punctuated by captivating cultural performances that showcased a wide array of traditions from international students, renowned artists like Stone Bowry, and the broader UPSA community. The performances included music, dance, storytelling, and culinary exhibitions, offering attendees an immersive experience of the richness of cultural diversity. Renowned artist Stone Bowry electrified the audience with his performance, blending contemporary and traditional Ghanaian music, underscoring the dynamic interplay of cultural heritage and modern artistry. International students presented dances, music, and storytelling from their home countries, reflecting the global spirit of the event.



Culinary exhibitions featured diverse dishes worldwide, fostering a deeper understanding and appreciation of cultural traditions.

The Director of Programs and the Chairperson commended the range of performances and cuisines, noting how these moments foster empathy and create a sense of unity. The Chairperson humorously shared their excitement for trying out some of the showcased dishes, adding a touch of levity to the proceedings.

Conclusion

The Cultural Day at UPSA was a resounding success, providing a platform for the celebration of cultural diversity, the exchange of ideas, and the strengthening of community bonds. The event showcased the university's commitment to fostering an inclusive environment where differences are celebrated and unity is achieved through shared values. As UPSA looks forward to future cultural celebrations, the values highlighted during this event will continue to guide the community toward a more inclusive and interconnected future.



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